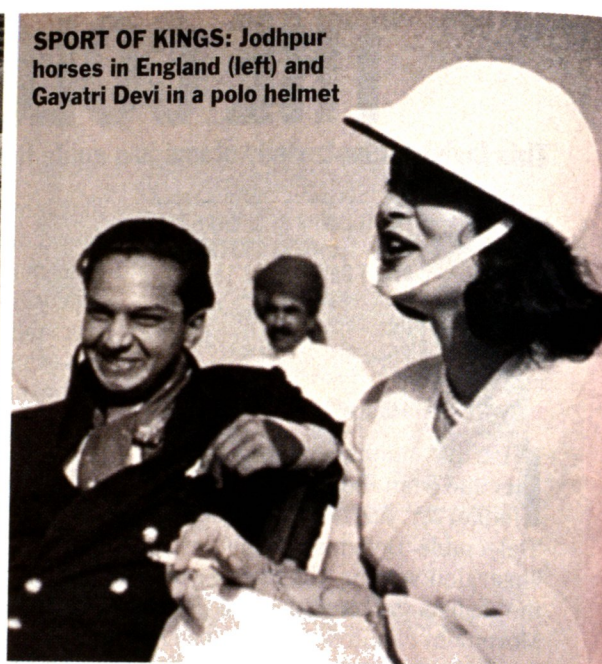




SPORT OF KINGS: Jodhpur horses in England (left) and Gayatri Devi in a polo helmet



ON A HIGH HORSE

Shorn of Page 3 bling, this is a timely reminder of India's royal contribution to the sport, its history and its future



POLO IN INDIA

by JAISAL SINGH, PRIYA KAPOOR

Roli Books

Price: Rs 2,975

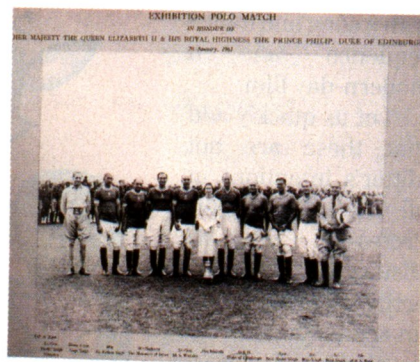
Pages: 190

■ By Dilip Bobb

It is Page 3 perfection: male studs in tight breeches, thundering hooves of sweat-streaked horses, glamorous women and high-profile sponsors. Come winter, and polo takes the celebrity quotient to a new high. Because of the coverage, more focused on the spectators and their designer-wear than the sport, polo has become a media bubble, with the sartorial more important than the score sheet. This book is a timely reminder that it

was the sport of kings and, for polo players and die-hard fans, the king of sports. For action, excitement and glamour, it is pretty unbeatable, and its royal antecedents give it a unique cachet.

Jaisal Singh, polo player and commentator, has collaborated with Priya Kapoor (whose talent for digging up rare photographs and archival material is once again in evidence) to produce the definitive book on the sport in India and the patrons and players who provided it such grace and glamour. India's contribution to the game is immense: modern polo originated in Manipur and India has produced some of the world's best players and teams. Starting with its origins, the rise of the princely states, the contribution of the army, the golden years when Indian teams dominated the world polo scene and the status of the game today, this is an invaluable book for anyone with the remotest interest in the sport and its magnificent history. Studded with plenty of interesting anecdotes and details, this is, however, largely a



GLOBE TROT: Queen Elizabeth and Prince Philip at a polo match in India

picture book with some rare archival photographs from private collections.

There is also a chapter on international polo but it is the Indian stars who shine through and are finally given due recognition—players like Hanut Singh of Jodhpur who had a handicap of +5 when he was 14 years old (+10 is the maximum any player can achieve); his father, Sir Pratap, the 'father of polo'; contemporary players like Billy and Pickles Sodhi, the Kalaans, V.P. Singh, Rupi Brar, Kuldeep Garcha, the Godara clan, Samir Suhag et al. At a time when cricket dominates the media, this book comes as a timely reminder that Indian sport's greatest moments have come on the polo fields of the world. ■

